

balmy nights, for nine or ten months a year you can forget about Spain—or any other part of Europe.

Farther to the north and east, Barcelona is the capital of Catalonia. Fifty years ago Barcelona was the manufacturing, artistic, and cultural center of Spain. But Franco hated the Catalonians, and during his three decades of rule he shifted the country's power to Madrid. Upon Franco's death in 1975, the Catalonians fell into a small-minded, nationalist backlash. Franco forbade the teaching and use of Catalanian, so Catalonians now want to limit the use of Spanish and other languages. Street signs, tourist maps, museum guides, billboards, and promotional flyers are in Catalanian, leaving the tourist little access to the heart of the city. Much manufacturing moved to Madrid and other parts of Spain, so Catalonians want to require that only locally produced goods be sold there. Franco built up the museums in Madrid, so Catalonians seldom exhibit Spanish art.

Barcelona won the right to host the Olympic games in 1992. You can bet the Catalonians will publish programs, press kits, schedules, and other information exclusively in their own language. Foreign swimmers, I suppose, will have to learn to speak Catalanian to find out where the pool is. Fanatics will try to prohibit the use of foreign languages at any time. They'll insist that groups of athletes from, say, China speak to one another in Catalanian.

Many Basques in the north want independence, but rather than make their country inaccessible to tourists, they open it up. We found the Basques as friendly as anyone in Spain, eager to help and see to it that we had a good time. Advertisements, tourist material, and street signs are in both Spanish and Basque, and tourist material is in English. To force the independence issue, a tiny group of Basque terrorists have been bombing their country for years. But the terrorists target local officials rather than tourists. Your chances of getting caught in the crossfire are remote. You're safer in Basque cities like San Sebastián or Bilbao, for example, than in